

Designing with your users, not for them

Participatory approaches for repositories. Take-away | FIDELIS Support Programme #3 | 30 September 2026 | Monika Mačiulienė, Lithuanian Citizen Science Association, VILNIUS TECH

Summary Researchers scan repository pages under deadline, looking for a few words that match their task. Interviews and journey maps show which words; design puts them where readers look first.

1. How a busy head reads and decides

- **We scan.** Users read about 20% of the text on an average web page (Nielsen Norman Group). The eye stops on words that match the task in hand (upload, DOI, deadline, format), on names it already cares about (the funder, the journal) and on a few trigger words (free, fast, you).
- **The choice is fast.** A repository is chosen in minutes, at the deadline, by the fast, automatic system Kahneman calls System 1. Comparing certifications is System 2 work, and nobody with a deadline runs it. Hence researchers can trust a repository and still deposit elsewhere.
- **Fast decisions follow shortcuts.** Cialdini's principles below. Repository pages already use some of them (e.g. seals). Used openly and with correct information, they save researchers time.

Shortcut	What it means	At your repository
Reciprocity	We repay what we are given.	Give first: a DOI within minutes, a citation line, a usage note later. Then ask for metadata.
A head start	We finish goals we can see progress on.	Pre-fill the deposit form from the data management plan.
Commitment	We act in line with what we said in public.	The DMP is a commitment. Quote it back, kindly, at the deadline.
Social proof	When unsure, we do what people like us do.	Real numbers: who in their faculty deposited with you this year.
Authority	We follow signs of competence we recognise.	Put CoreTrustSeal next to the funder's name and the journal's policy, never alone.
Scarcity	Fear of losing moves us more than hope of gaining.	Real deadlines only (the funder's, the journal's). Researchers notice invented urgency.

2. Checklist: design for scanning readers

Guideline page

- ☐ One idea per paragraph. Headings that say what the section does.
- ☐ Task words in headings and in bold: upload, format, DOI, deadline.
- ☐ Short sentences, no internal jargon. Test the reading level.
- ☐ Contrast and white space, so the eye knows where to start.
- ☐ Certification, policies, licences one click away, below the fold.

Correction email (the lowest point of the journey)

- ☐ First line: what to do, and how long it takes.
- ☐ One list, one problem per line, the fix next to each problem.
- ☐ Field names in bold. White space between items.
- ☐ Same layout every time. One button: fix it now.

Deposit form and button

- ☐ About seven fields before the DOI exists. The rest after.
- ☐ Fields pre-filled from the data management plan where possible.
- ☐ One button, visible, in a colour nothing else uses.
- ☐ The button says what happens next and how long it takes. Not "Submit".
- ☐ Test the wording on three depositors before you change it.

The three touchpoints

- Researchers deal with the repository at three touchpoints: the data management plan, the publication deadline and the funder report. Put the accents there:
- ☐ One line of text in the DMP template your institution offers.
 - ☐ The deposit form at the deadline.
 - ☐ A line they can paste into the funder report.

3. Keep it honest

The promise sentence, in every invitation

You decide _____. We decide _____. We tell you what happened by _____. [Name] carries what you said into our decisions.

Report back within a month, also when the answer is "no, because the audit requires this field".

4. Five conversations with depositors, and other sources

Invitation (copy, fill in, send)

Dear [name], we want depositing with [repository] to take less of your time. Could you give us 30 minutes on [date] or [date] to tell us about the last time you deposited data, anywhere? You decide what we change in [the deposit form / the correction email], we decide what is technically possible, and we will tell you what changed by [date].

The five questions

1. Tell me about the last dataset you deposited anywhere. Where did it go, and why there?
2. Walk me through it, from the data management plan to after publication. What happened at each point?
3. Was anything sent back to you? What did you do next?
4. What did you get after the deposit? Anything you noticed later?
5. If the next deposit took half the time, what would have to change?

Rules: thirty minutes, two of you (one asks, one writes). Ask about the last time and avoid “usually”. Ask why, even when you know the answer. Ask for the story, then be quiet. Note where they stopped. Recruit on purpose: one person whose submission came back, one who trusts you and has never deposited.

Not only interviews

What they do: site search terms and analytics, researcher profiles and data availability statements in recent papers, observing a researcher while they deposit.

What they say: helpdesk tickets and correction emails, discipline mailing lists and forums, a two-question survey after the DOI.

Also: deposit a test dataset in two other repositories, and talk to your most frequent depositor and to someone who gave up.

5. The depositor persona (two at most, built from the interviews)

Name and role Who, and at which career stage	The week and the trigger What fills it; what made them deposit last time	What they scan for The three words on your page that matter to them
One sentence they said Verbatim, from the interview	The fear What they expect to go wrong	Where the accent goes Which page, form or email, which line

Leave a field empty rather than invent it. An empty field is a question for the next conversation.

6. The deposit journey (fill it from your last five submissions)

Phase	Data management plan	Data collection	Publication deadline	Deposit	Returned for correction	Published	Afterwards
Doing What they do							
Thinking Their words							
Feeling + 0 -							
Accent What your page, form or email says here							

Black = the three touchpoints, where the accents belong. Look for rapid drops on the feeling line (usually the returned submission) and for the flat stretch after publication, where nothing comes back.

7. This week

Three things for one afternoon (no budget, no permission)

1. Rewrite the correction email for scanning readers (section 2).
2. Book five conversations. Send the invitation in section 4.
3. Map your last five submissions on the journey in section 6. Mark where your accents are now, and where they should be.

Repeat the session's two exercises with your team

- **Your last three contacts.** Each person writes what the last three researchers who contacted you wanted. Sort them by touchpoint. Is there a fourth?
- **One page, one persona.** Scan your own deposit page for one minute as one of your personas. What do they need, where is it now, what would you move to the top?

Sources: Krug, S. (2014) Don't Make Me Think, Revisited. Nielsen, J. (2008) How little do users read? Nielsen Norman Group. Kahneman, D. (2011) Thinking, Fast and Slow. Cialdini, R. (2021) Influence, new and expanded edition. Madrian, B. and Shea, D. (2001) Quarterly Journal of Economics 116(4). Foster, N. F. and Gibbons, S. (2005) D-Lib Magazine 11(1). Tenopir, C. et al. (2011) PLoS ONE 6(6). Digital Science (2023) The State of Open Data 2023. CoreTrustSeal Requirements 2023-2025, v01.00.